backlash, some (albeit not all) of which has taken Islamist form. Religious elements have come to the fore with a force to find solutions within the teachings of Islam. This phenomenon has been witnessed in the Caucasus, Algeria and the Indian sub-continent.

Russians conquered Chechnya in May 1859. Since then, Russia has tried to suppress Islam there. These attempts have always earned a strong backlash. In the nineteenth century, Dagestan and Chechnya were groaning under the Russian domination until Imam Shamil, a Muslim political, military and religious leader, unleashed a freedom struggle. He considered the endless feuds among the Caucasian clans that resulted from the tribal system and strived to replace it with *Sharia* or Muslim law. The peoples of both Dagestan and Chechnya revered him as their Imam (a divinely inspired religious leader). Many other Muslim figures, such as sheikhs, imams and qadis, led the national liberation movements in different parts of the region. The Sufi movement in north-eastern Caucasus, historically better known as Muridism, was the Russian Empire's nemesis. Therefore, it was not surprising that after the war, Russian authorities set out to destroy the base of Sufi teachings in the region. Sheikhs were exiled under the Tsars, while under the Bolsheviks, they were shot.

Sufism, which has become the way of life for the Chechens for the past 150 years, went underground under the pressure of the Bolsheviks' militant atheism when they came to power. This made it possible for Sufis in Chechnya and Dagestan to preserve the practices they followed during the nineteenth-century Russian–Caucasian war. This included, for example, paying extreme veneration to the tombstones of sheikhs who were killed during the war and considered *Shaheeds* (martyrs) (Blank, 2012).

In the Indian sub-continent, this trend started in the eighteenth century when call for jihad was made after the East India Company won the Battle of Plassey in 1757, and some quarters of Muslims strongly felt that the British were bent upon wresting the power from Muslim rulers (Aziz, 2011). Shah Waliullah (1703–62), a Muslim reformist, advocated armed jihad to restore Muslim power in South Asia (Lieven, 2011). One important instance was that the family of Shah Waliullah, in association with other ulema, despatched 800 warriors from eastern India to the Pashtun belt to organise jihad, first against the Sikhs and later against the British who replaced the former as rulers in 1849 (Aziz, 2011).